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Bose-Rolland Interview

As I rang the bell of Romain Rolland's house in Villeneuve, the door was opened by a lady of short stature, but with an exceedingly sympathetic and lively face. This was Madame Romain Rolland. Hardly had she greeted me than another door opened in front of us and there emerged a tall figure with a pale countenance and with wonderful penetrating eyes. Yes, this was the face I had seen in many a picture before, a face that seemed to be burdened with the sorrows of humanity. There was something exquisitely sad in that pallid face—but it was not an expression of defeatism. For no sooner did he began to speak, than colour rushed to his white cheeks—the eyes glowed with a light that was uncommon—and the words that he poured forth were pregnant with life and hope.

My purpose was to discuss with him the latest developments in the Indian situation and to ascertain his present views on the important problems before the world. I had therefore to do much of the talking at first, in order to explain the Indian situation as I analysed and comprehended it. The two cardinal principles on which the movement of the last 14 years had been based were—firstly, Satyagraha or non-violent resistance, and secondly, a united front of all sections of the Indian people, e.g., capital and labour and landlord and peasant.

India's great hope was that the Satyagraha movement would fructify in a peaceful settlement in the following manner. Within India, the movement would gradually paralyse the civil administration of the country. Outside India, the lofty ethics of Satyagraha would stir the conscience of the British people. Thus would the conflict lead to a settlement, whereby India would win her

[1] Full text of Netaji's report on his interview with M. Romain Rolland in Villeneuve, Switzerland in April 1935.